

EcoTipping Points Facilitation Guides

Constraints Worksheet

Reality-check your approach before committing to it.

The best intervention is one your community group can actually carry out. This worksheet helps you test a proposed approach against real conditions, not ideal ones, so you can design something that fits.

Use this after you've identified a potential intervention (Reverse It) and before you commit time and resources.

Name your potential intervention

What are you planning to do? Describe it in a few sentences:

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What does this approach need to work?

For each category, write down what your approach requires and what's actually available. Be specific and honest. A gap here isn't a reason to quit — it's information you need to design well.

PEOPLE AND LABOR

[illegible]

What does this approach need to work?

For each category, write down what your approach requires and what's actually available. Be specific and honest. A gap here isn't a reason to quit — it's information you need to design well.

MONEY AND MATERIALS

[illegible]

What does this approach need to work?

For each category, write down what your approach requires and what's actually available. Be specific and honest. A gap here isn't a reason to quit — it's information you need to design well.

KNOWLEDGE AND SKILLS

[illegible]

What does this approach need to work?

For each category, write down what your approach requires and what's actually available. Be specific and honest. A gap here isn't a reason to quit — it's information you need to design well.

TIME

[illegible]

Who might resist, and what can they do about it?

Identify specific people, groups, or institutions that might oppose the approach and what power they actually hold.

EXAMPLE: In the Rainwater Harvesting success story, the government tried to shut down construction of traditional dams by Gopalpura community members. In the Pesticide Trap success story, pesticide dealers threatened farmers with debt collection. Knowing who might push back — and how — lets you plan for it rather than be surprised by it.

[illegible]

What are you depending on that you don't control?

List anything external your approach requires but that you can't guarantee: government permits, donor approval, market access, cooperation from neighboring communities, weather patterns, supply chains.

For each one: what happens to your plan if this doesn't come through?

[illegible]

The risk question

Answer the questions below to understand the risk involved in your approach. The question isn't whether your approach is right; it's whether the path to it fits what people can actually risk.

***EXAMPLE:** In the Agroforestry success story, Khao Din farmers couldn't afford to abandon cash crops overnight. A bad harvest could mean starvation. They converted gradually, field by field, learning as they went.*

What happens to the community if this approach fails or takes much longer than expected?

Can families absorb the cost of failure, or would it make things worse?

Is there a way to start small enough that failure is survivable?

What's the minimum viable version of this approach: the smallest thing you could try that would still tell you whether it's working?

Before you move on

Your approach should reflect what your community group can actually do, not what would work in ideal conditions. A smaller intervention that fits real constraints will outperform an ambitious one that falls apart.

Three signs your approach is well-matched to your situation:

1. The resources it needs are things the community already has or can realistically get.
2. You can describe the first concrete step, and people know who's doing it.
3. If it goes wrong, the community isn't worse off than before.

If you're modifying, write your revised approach here:

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